

Political & Economic Thought — Master Notes

by Jakob V. Stangel

One running document for the whole course, organised **by module**. Format per reading: **Résumé** → ★
Heart of it → Key concepts → Section-by-section → Cases → Key terms → Exam pointers.

Overview — where everything is

(Everything below is clickable — jump straight to a week, reading, case, or fun-facts box.)

- **Module 1: Antiquity & the Middle Ages — Greeks & Romans** — ★ Lecture 1 (BAP/JL) · Reeve: Plato · McClelland: Aristotle · Galbraith intro · ★ Reading questions (answered) · ★ Fun facts
- **Module 2: Renaissance & Early-Modern — from Cosmopolis to Stato to Social Contract** — McClelland: Hobbes · Hobbes's social covenant · Grotius: natural law & the world system of states · Hobbes vs Grotius · ★ Fun facts

Module 1: Antiquity and the Middle Ages — Greeks and Romans

Readings: Reeve on Plato · McClelland on Aristotle · Galbraith intro (pp. 1–8)

Theme of the module: the two founders of Western political thought — **Plato** (the ideal state built on knowledge of the Good) and **Aristotle** (the empirical, "natural" study of the *polis*) — paired with Galbraith's framing of *how to read the history of economic ideas* (ideas as products of their time). Plato gives the **normative/idealist** pole, Aristotle the **empirical/naturalist** pole; both anchor every later debate.

★ **The red thread** — each text in **ONE idea** (keep these three in view; all the detail below hangs off them):

- **Reeve → Plato:** rule belongs to those who **KNOW the Good** — politics is *derived from metaphysics* (the philosopher-king in the kallipolis).
- **McClelland → Aristotle:** the **polis is natural**, studied **empirically** — judge every constitution by whose interest it serves (good vs corrupt; **politeia** = the best *practicable*).
- **Galbraith:** economic ideas are **products of their own time and place** — read ideas against the world that made them.

★ Lecture 1 (BAP/JL) — The roots of political philosophy

The lecture (Benjamin Ask Popp-Madsen · Joachim Lund) frames the whole field, then walks the ancient arc **Greece → Rome → early Christianity**. The readings below give the Plato/Aristotle/economics detail; this section adds the lecture's **framing** and the **Roman/Christian** material it covers beyond the readings. (Course/exam: written sit-in on CBS computers, Jan 2027; 7-step scale; two internal examiners.)

| What is Political and Economic Thought? — theory vs. ideology

Core: both **theory** and **ideology** are "frameworks of explanation," but theory *aims at objectivity* (a **positive**, not normative, starting point — though never value-free), while ideology is openly **normative** — a programme for action.

- **Ideology** (Heywood): a coherent set of ideas grounding organised political action — it ① describes the existing order (a "world-view"), ② pictures a "good society," ③ says how to get from ①→②.
- **Theory:** rigorous concepts + logic aiming at some **objectivity**; a relatively rigorous (not strictly scientific) form of knowledge.
- So both sit on a **continuum between science and ideology** / positive vs normative. (Watch words like "right" and "just" — they sound like theory but smuggle in norms.)

| Why study the history of ideas? — do ideas change the world?

Core: the course's central puzzle — do **ideas** move history, or do **material interests**?

- **Hegel:** "Philosophy comes too late to teach the world what it should be." • **Marx:** "philosophers have only *interpreted* the world; the point is to *change* it." • **Weber:** interests govern conduct, but the "world-images" created by ideas act like **switchmen** on the tracks. • **Gramsci** (*cultural hegemony*): the dominant ideas decide how socio-economic structures *can* be changed.

| Three kinds of social theory

- **Political theory** — the **authoritative distribution of scarce resources** / the monopoly of violence.
- **Sociological theory** — human behaviour in and between groups.
- **Economic theory** — the **creation & distribution of wealth** (→ close to politics at the macro level, to sociology at the micro level).

| Ancient Greece — the polis (context)

Core: the setting is the **polis** — the small, self-governing city-state — at its height ~500–400 BC, then eclipsed by Macedonian empire from **338 BC**.

- ~1,500 **Greek city-states**; typically 500–2,000 free adult male citizens each; **Athens** ~40,000 citizens (~200,000 total incl. women, children, slaves, metics).
- Democracy's arc: **Solon (594 BC)** & **Cleisthenes (508 BC)** extend citizenship → **Persian Wars** → **Peloponnesian War (431–404 BC, Athens defeated)** → **338 BC** Philip of Macedon ends Athenian

democracy → 322 BC Athens no longer independent (Aristotle dies that year).

Plato & Aristotle — the lecture's framing

(Full detail in the Reeve and McClelland notes; here are the lecture's sharp contrasts.)

- **Plato** (427–347 BC): scarred by Athens' defeat (404) and **Socrates' execution (399)** → *unimpressed by democracy*. The kallipolis realises the Good; 3 soul-parts / 3 classes (producers = money-lovers · guardians = honour-lovers · philosopher-rulers = wisdom-lovers = "aristocracy").
- **Aristotle** (384–322 BC): a **foreigner (metic)** in Athens; **empiricist** — studied **150+ constitutions**; aims at **eudaimonia** (the good life); "identify those aspects of political life which operate **as nature intended**." Natural law reflected in human law; **natural pairs** (master–slave, husband–wife, father–child, ruler–ruled); some are "slaves by nature."
- **Aristotle's constitutions** — *in whose interest?* (the good/corrupt test):

Rule by...	Common interest (just)	Rulers' interest (corrupt)
One	Monarchy	Tyranny
A few	Aristocracy	Oligarchy
Many	<u>Politeia</u>	Democracy

- **Plato vs Aristotle in one line:** Plato asks "*which men are most able to govern?*" (from assumptions about human nature → rule by **sophia/wisdom**); Aristotle asks "*what would it take to be a good ruler?*" (from observation → **phronesis/practical wisdom**, plus **taking turns, accountability, legitimacy**). Aristotle distrusts rule by pure *sophia*.

Politeia — Aristotle's best *practicable* constitution

Core: *politeia* (polity) = the good, common-interest form of rule by the many, and Aristotle's **best constitution actually achievable** for ordinary cities (a perfectly-virtuous monarch or aristocracy being rare). It is his real answer to "*who should rule?*"

- A "**mixed**" constitution: it **blends democracy and oligarchy** and rests on a strong **middle class**, which makes it **stable** — the middle moderates between rich and poor, so neither extreme captures the state.
- Its **three principles** (the lecture's framing):
 - **Phronesis over sophia** — good rule needs **practical wisdom from experience**, not abstract wisdom alone (Aristotle's implicit critique of Plato's philosopher-king).
 - **Taking turns** → **accountability** — citizens rule *and are ruled* in turn.
 - **Everyone shares in lawmaking** → **legitimacy**.
- **Vs Plato:** Plato — "*which men are most able to govern?*" → rule by the knowing few (**sophia**). Aristotle — "*what makes a good ruler?*" → **shared, accountable** rule by the many (**phronesis**). **Politeia is Aristotle's real-world answer to "who should rule."**
- **Terminology watch:** *politeia* also means "**constitution**" in general (and gives us the word "politics") — here it names the *specific* good form of majority rule (the just counterpart of **democracy**, which for

Aristotle is the *corrupt* form).

Rome — republic, law & clientelism

Core: Rome adds the **mixed constitution** and the **rule of law** — but on a **weak civil state** riddled with **clientelism**.

- **Polybius & Cicero:** Republican Rome was best because it **mixed** monarchy (two **consuls**), aristocracy (the **Senate**) and democracy (the **People's Assembly** / **tribunes**).
- **Rule of law:** Cicero brings **Natural Law** ("the true law of reason according to Nature") to Rome; expressed in **ius gentium** (law of peoples) & **ius civile** (law of citizens). Roman law = codified **protection of life & property** from government abuse; introduces **contracts & corporations**. But a **weak state** (no police, no public prosecutor — only the wealthy could bring a case) → power rested on the **strongest army** and on **clientelism** (patron–client bonds of power, dependency & obligation — *not* rights).
- Arc: kingdom (753 BC) → **Republic (509–49 BC)** → Caesar assassinated (44 BC) → **Augustus**, first emperor (27 BC); **Caracalla (AD 212)** grants citizenship to all free men.

From Stoicism to Christianity

Core: the **Stoics** universalise **natural law** — everyone is born with equal **logos** (reason) — the first hint that **all are in principle equal**, later carried into Christianity.

- **Stoicism:** equal *logos* → slavery & the suppression of women are *unnatural*; **Seneca:** a citizen may be legally free yet morally a slave — seek **spiritual** freedom. Transferred to Christianity: freedom = **submission to faith**; all equal **in God's eyes** (created in His image).
- **Augustine (354–430):** **two states** (God's and Man's); **Natural Law** = Divine Law; true freedom only in Paradise; slavery = God's punishment for sin.
- **Aquinas (1224–74):** peace & God's **Cosmopolis**; man submits to divine authority (God & pope); a **moral economy**.

Ancient economic thinking

Core: economics = **household (oikos) management** on land & slavery; **trade is inferior**/"unnatural," and **usury** (money-lending) is immoral.

- **Xenophon's Oikonomikos:** wealth from good **estate management**. Exchange was **hierarchical**, only partly market-based; distribution via **gifts, plunder, tribute, prizes, local markets**.
- **Just prices vs artificial prices;** money-lending = **usury** = immoral. Ideal: "*rich enough to pursue virtue*" (Greeks: no excess; Romans: wealth = responsibility). (*This is where Galbraith's & Backhouse's "ancient world" economics begins.*)

Greek & Roman terms we still use

- **Greek:** *politeia* (affairs of the city) → **politics** · *monos+archo* → **monarchy** · *aristos+kratos* → **aristocracy** · *demos+kratos* → **democracy** · *tyrannos* → **tyranny** · *oikos+nemein* (household + manage) → **economy**.

- **Latin:** *res publica* → **republic** · *imperium* → **empire** · *dictator* → **dictatorship** · *civitas* → **citizen/city** · *populus* → **people/populism** · **constitution** (how things are constituted).

Take-away — ancient political philosophy

- It debated natural law vs the laws of the state; reflected on justice, rule of law, and forms of constitution/government; and weighed duty to the family (*oikos*) against duty to the polis and religion → the enduring question of **individual freedom vs. obligation to society**.

Reeve — 'Plato'

In: David Boucher & Paul Kelly (eds), *Political Thinkers* (2003), **ch. 4**, by **C.D.C. Reeve** (pp. 55–72). Main text: Plato, *Republic*.

Chapter résumé

An analytic tour of Plato's political philosophy, built almost entirely on the **Republic**. Reeve shows how Plato's **metaphysics** (the Theory of **Forms**, crowned by the **Form of the Good**) grounds his **politics**: since only the philosopher *knows* the Good, only the philosopher-king should rule. He walks through the ideal city (kallipolis): its origin in the division of labour, its tripartite structure mirroring the tripartite soul, and **justice** as everyone "doing their own" job. He then confronts the notorious features — the **noble lie**, abolition of family and property for the guardians, equality of women, eugenics, exposure of infants, slavery, and **censorship of art** — before ending on the clash with modern **liberal freedom**: Plato restricts liberty because he aims at citizens' *real* good, which (he thinks) requires being ruled by knowledge.

★ **The heart of the chapter:** Plato's politics falls straight out of his **metaphysics** — because only the philosopher *knows* the Form of the Good, only the **philosopher-king** should rule; and **justice = each class doing its own job** in the kallipolis.

Key concepts / "modes" to use

- **Theory of Forms & the Form of the Good** (the "good-itself") — the metaphysical foundation.
- Philosopher-king — rule belongs to those who *know* the Good.
- Tripartite soul / city: appetitive → producers (money-lovers); spirited → guardians/auxiliaries (honour-lovers); rational → rulers (wisdom-lovers).
- **Justice = specialization** ("doing one's own work"), the principle that structures the whole city.
- **Sun / Line / Cave** analogies — how we know the Good.
- **The three cities**: City-1 (healthy/"true"), City-2 (luxurious/"feverish"), City-3 (purified = kallipolis).
- **Genuine lie vs verbal lie** (the "noble lie" / myth of the metals).

Section-by-section main points

Biography & framing

- Plato c. 429–347 BC, from a leading aristocratic Athenian family (related to Solon; brothers **Glaucon & Adeimantus** appear in the *Republic*). Founded the **Academy**. The **execution of Socrates (399 BC)** turned him away from a political career toward philosophy.
- **Key texts:** the *Republic* is central; Plato's dialogues are grouped into four chronological sets (early/Socratic → late).

An overview of the *Republic*

- **Book 1** — Thrasymachus: "justice is the **interest of the stronger**." Socrates' refutation (*elenchus*) is inadequate; **Glaucon & Adeimantus** renew the challenge, demanding justice be shown **intrinsically** (not just instrumentally) good.
- Plato's answer: the just city ruled by **philosopher-kings** who possess **knowledge of the Form of the Good** (not mere opinion). Political rule should go to those *best fitted by knowledge*.
- The city's three classes are produced by **eugenics + the "noble lie"**. Guardians live under a form of **communism** (no private property or family) so that no private interest competes with the city's good. **Censorship** shapes character.
- **Justice** = each person/class performing the **one social role** they are naturally best fitted for.

Forms and the good-itself

- Discussion of poetry (Books 2–3) leads to **Forms** as eternal **patterns/blueprints** (of virtues, of a good city).
- **Sun analogy:** the **Good** is to the intelligible realm what the sun is to the visible — the source both of things' **being** and of their **knowability**. Rational order = goodness = intelligibility.
- Knowing the **good-itself** is what lets the philosopher make the kallipolis genuinely good (it is the "cause" of a thing's good order).

The structure of the *kallipolis*

- The ideal city is developed in three stages: **City-1** (the healthy "true" city), **City-2** (the luxurious/"feverish" city, once appetites expand), **City-3** (the purified city = kallipolis).
- The kallipolis is a **real possibility**, not an idle utopia — but only if **philosopher-kings** rule.

Specialization

- **Principle of specialization / unique-aptitude doctrine:** each does the single job their nature suits them for. This is the foundation of **justice**.
- Reeve notes Plato really relies on **quasi-specialization** — three broad natural types (money-lovers, honour-lovers, wisdom-lovers), not a unique craft per person.

| The lies of the rulers

- **Genuine ("true") lie** = a false belief in the soul about the most important things — *always* bad.
- **Verbal lie** = words that mislead — can be a useful "**medicine**," legitimately used by rulers (like the myth of the metals) for the city's good.
- Only the **philosopher-kings**, who *know* the good, are entitled to deploy such lies.

| Private life and private property

- Guardians have **no private property and no private family** — a "communism" of the ruling classes — to remove competing private interests.
- **Women guardians** are trained and rule alongside men: the principle of specialization applies to individuals regardless of sex (though child-bearing is noted). Plato is **not a feminist**, but the implication is radical for its time.
- Reproduction managed by a rigged lottery / community of wives & children (a eugenics programme).

| Invalids, infants, slaves

- **Medicine** should restore people to a worthwhile life, **not prolong** lives too ill to function; deformed **infants** are (controversially) exposed — Reeve flags this as debated.
- **Slavery**: the kallipolis probably contains slaves (barbarian, not Greek), but Plato's position is ambiguous and less central than Aristotle's.

| Censorship of the arts

- Poetry and art are **censored** because they misrepresent gods and virtue, feed the **appetitive** (not rational) part of the soul, and weaken character. Art must **serve education**. This is Plato's famous **quarrel with poetry**.

| Freedom and autonomy

- Modern **liberal** objection: the kallipolis crushes individual freedom.
- Reeve's reconstruction of Plato's reply: distinguish a person's **real interests** (what truly fulfils their nature → real happiness) from mere **desires**. Liberal **instrumental/negative freedom** (satisfy whatever desires you happen to have) may not serve real interests; **deliberative freedom** requires the right education and knowledge.
- Because the kallipolis aims at citizens' **real good**, Plato claims it delivers *more* real freedom (fulfilment) even while restricting license. Liberal **neutrality among conceptions of the good** is itself a contestable value.

Cases & examples

Plato argues through **thought-experiments and images**, not country cases — but you're expected to know these cold, so here's *what each one actually says*.

- **Thrasymachus's challenge (Book 1).** The sophist Thrasymachus asserts that "**justice is the interest of the stronger**" — rulers simply make laws that serve themselves and call it "just." Socrates' on-the-spot refutation (the *elenchus*) is weak, so **Glaucón and Adeimantus** re-pose the challenge: show that justice is good **in itself**, not just for its rewards. → *Sets up the entire argument of the Republic* — everything after is Plato's answer.
- **The three cities.** Plato builds the ideal city in stages: **City-1**, the "healthy"/"true" city of simple needs; **City-2**, the "luxurious"/"feverish" city once appetites and luxuries balloon (now it needs a guardian/soldier class); and **City-3**, the **purified** city — the kallipolis — once reason (the philosopher-kings) governs the whole. → *Shows the kallipolis is reached by purifying a realistic city, not conjured from nothing.*
- **The Sun analogy.** Just as the sun both lets us **see** objects and makes them **grow**, the **Form of the Good** makes the other Forms both **knowable** and gives them their very **being**. → *Illustrates why the Good is the highest object of knowledge and the source of the city's goodness — the metaphysical root of rule by philosophers.*
- **The Allegory of the Cave.** Prisoners chained facing a wall take flickering **shadows** for reality; one is freed, dazzled by the sunlight, and slowly comes to see real things and finally the sun itself. → *Illustrates education as turning the soul from appearances toward the Good — and why the enlightened philosopher must (reluctantly) go back down to rule.*
- **The myth of the metals (the noble lie).** Citizens are told a "needful" story: that god mixed **gold** into the rulers, **silver** into the auxiliaries, and **bronze/iron** into the producers at birth. → *Illustrates the "lies of the rulers" — a verbal lie used to legitimate the class structure and secure loyalty to the city.*
- **The rigged marriage lottery.** Guardian reproduction is arranged by a lottery that is secretly **fixed** so the "best" breed with the "best," while the couples believe the pairing was pure chance. → *Illustrates Plato's eugenics and the abolition of the private family among the guardians.*

Key terms

Term	Meaning
Form / Theory of Forms	Eternal, intelligible patterns; the true objects of knowledge
Form of the Good (good-itself)	Highest Form; source of being & knowability (Sun analogy)
Philosopher-king	Ruler who <i>knows</i> the Good; only they should rule
Tripartite soul	Rational / spirited / appetitive parts
Three classes	Rulers (wisdom) / guardians-auxiliaries (honour) / producers (money)
Justice	Each part/class doing its own proper work (specialization)
Kallipolis	Plato's ideal ("beautiful") city
Noble lie / myth of the metals	Verbal lie used to legitimate the class structure
Genuine vs verbal lie	False belief in the soul (always bad) vs misleading words (can be useful)
Real interests vs desires	What truly fulfils us vs what we happen to want

Exam pointers

- Be able to trace the **metaphysics → politics** move: Form of the Good → philosopher-king → kallipolis.
- Know the **soul ↔ city** parallel and **justice = specialization** codd.
- Distinguish genuine vs verbal lie and explain why the noble lie is (for Plato) permissible.
- Be ready to state Plato's **anti-liberal** account of freedom (real interests vs desires).

McClelland — Aristotle

Book: J.S. McClelland, *A History of Western Political Thought* (1996), pp. 52–68 (chapter section "Aristotle and the Science of Politics", in Part "The Greeks").

Chapter résumé

McClelland presents Aristotle as the **empirical, scientific** counterpart to Plato. After a biographical sketch (the Macedonian connection, the Lyceum), he tackles the textual "**problem**" — the *Politics* is a jumbled, probably lecture-derived text (Jaeger's developmental thesis). His central claim: Aristotle's political science is **empirical in the way his biology is** — it studies the *polis* as a natural organism, takes **received opinion** seriously, and asks what **nature intends**. The reading then maps the eight books of the *Politics*, and develops two big Aristotelian doctrines: the **naturalness of rulership** (natural hierarchies, the household, slavery) and the **naturalness of the polis** (man as a *political animal*, the *polis* as the *telos* of human community, and the classification of constitutions).

★ **The heart of the chapter:** Aristotle studies politics **empirically, like biology** — the **polis exists by nature** (man is a political animal), and regimes are judged **good vs. corrupt** by whether they serve the **common interest** (the six-fold classification of constitutions).

Key concepts / "modes" to use

- **Teleology** — everything has an *end* (*telos*); "nature does nothing in vain."
- **Empirical method** — study politics like biology; give **received opinion** (*endoxa*) a hearing.
- **Naturalness of the polis** — man is by nature a **political animal**; the *polis* exists by nature and is **prior** to the individual.
- **Natural rulership** — some rule / some are ruled by nature (master–slave, husband–wife, parent–child).
- **Classification of constitutions** — 3 good vs 3 corrupt forms.
- **Phronesis** (practical wisdom) vs **sophia** (theoretical wisdom); rule of law vs rule of men.

Section-by-section main points

Biography

- Born **384 BC in Stageira** (Macedonian Thrace); father was court physician to the Macedonian king. Studied ~20 years at **Plato's Academy**. Tutored the young **Alexander the Great**. Founded his own school, the **Lyceum** (covered walk = *peripatos* → "**Peripatetics**"), with a vast curriculum — "the first real university." Left Athens twice amid **anti-Macedonian** feeling; died at **Chalcis, 322 BC**.

The Problem of Aristotle's *Politics*

- Aristotle was Plato's pupil but **broke away**; the *Politics* is famously **disorganised** — possibly a compilation of **lecture notes**.
- **Jaeger's thesis**: distinguish the "**Original Politics**" (Books 2, 3, 7, 8 — Platonic, about the ideal/best state) from the truly "**Aristotelian Politics**" (Books 4, 5, 6 — empirical), with **Book 1** written last as a general introduction.
- Aristotle's political science is **empirical like his biology**: study how politics actually works, and give **common/received opinion** ("even the mistakes of the past can be instructive") a sympathetic hearing.
- "**Nature does nothing without a purpose**." Political science is **useful**: identify what nature *intends* and amend what frustrates it — Aristotle is **not** merely the theorist of the second-best.

A Map of the *Politics*

- **Book 1** — the *polis* exists by nature (against the Sophist "convention only" view); defence of natural **slavery**; the household & the acquisition of wealth (original meaning of "**economics**"); natural rule based on possession of **reason**.
- **Book 2** — ideal communities; critique of **Plato's Republic** (community of wives/children, property); property best held **privately but used in common**.
- **Book 3** — definitions: *What is the polis?* = its **constitution**; *What is a citizen?* (one who shares in office/justice); the **classification of constitutions** — three **good** forms (**monarchy, aristocracy, politeia**) and their **corrupt** counterparts (**tyranny, oligarchy, democracy**); on kingship.
- **Books 4, 5, 6** — the **empirical heart**: the **morphology and pathology** of states; five key questions (how many kinds of constitution; which is best in normal circumstances; which suits which population; how to organise them; **how constitutions are preserved and destroyed**). **Book 5** = political **pathology and preventive medicine** (causes of revolution; how regimes are preserved — obedience to law).
- **Books 7, 8** — "Platonic": Aristotle on the **best state** (ideal population size, territory, and **education**).

The Naturalness of Rulership

- Aristotle's **teleological biology** drives the politics. Some things naturally **rule**, others are naturally **ruled**; the natural pairs are **master–slave, husband–wife, father–children**, combining into the **household**, then village, then *polis*.

- **Ends:** the *polis* is the *end* toward which lesser communities develop — "prior" in the sense of **completion**, not in time (the acorn/oak analogy).
- **Slavery:** the "natural slave" lacks the **deliberative/directive faculty** (reason); the master's intelligence directs him, as mind directs body. But Aristotle is **uneasy/embarrassed** — he concedes many actual slaves are enslaved by mere **convention/conquest** (the Sophist objection), so his defence is **weak** and applies only to a hypothetical "natural" slave.
- **Kingship** = rule of **intelligence over desire**, like soul over body; legitimate if the king rules in the interest of all.

| The Naturalness of the *Polis*

- **Phronesis** (practical wisdom for contingent human affairs) is distinct from **sophia** (theoretical wisdom); politics needs *phronesis*.
- The *polis* **exists by nature** as the *telos* of household → village → *polis*; **man is by nature a political animal**; the *polis* is **prior to the individual** (only in it can we live the "good life," not mere life).
- **Rule of law vs rule of men:** law should be supreme **in general**, with men deciding **particular** cases law can't foresee.
- Constitutions judged by whether rulers serve the **common interest** (good) or their **own** (corrupt); Aristotle allows that the **"many," collectively**, may be wiser than the few.

Notes on Sources (p. 68) — reading recommendations (Penguin *Politics*; Jaeger; Barker; Ross; MacIntyre's *After Virtue*).

Cases & examples

Aristotle reasons from **analogies and a classification scheme** — know these in semi-depth.

- **The six-fold classification of constitutions.** Aristotle sorts every regime along two axes — *who rules* (one / few / many) × *in whose interest* (the **common good** = correct; the **rulers' own** = corrupt): **monarchy** → **tyranny** (one), **aristocracy** → **oligarchy** (few), **polity** (*politeia*) → **democracy** (many). → *The core exam item:* a regime is "good" when it serves the common interest, "corrupt" when rulers serve themselves; note "democracy" is the *corrupt* form of majority rule (its good form is *politeia*).
- **The acorn and the oak (teleology).** As an acorn's *end* (*telos*) is to become an oak, the *end* of human association is the **polis**. So the polis is "prior" to the household and village not in *time* but as their **completion**. → *Illustrates why the polis is "natural" and why studying it means asking what it is for.*
- **Household → village → polis.** The natural pairs (**master–slave, husband–wife, parent–child**) form the **household** (*oikos*); households cluster into the **village**; villages combine into the self-sufficient **polis**, where the "good life" — not mere survival — first becomes possible. → *Illustrates the naturalness of the polis and the claim that man is by nature a political animal.*
- **The natural slave.** Aristotle claims some people are "slaves by nature": lacking the **deliberative faculty**, they are rightly directed by a master's reason, as the body is by the mind. But he immediately concedes that many *actual* slaves were enslaved only by **conquest or convention** (the Sophist objection) — so his own defence comes out **uneasy and weak**. → *Illustrates the clash between his tidy teleology and messy observed reality.*

Key terms

Term	Meaning
Telos / teleology	The natural <i>end</i> or purpose of a thing
Political animal (<i>zoon politikon</i>)	Humans are by nature made to live in a <i>polis</i>
Polis prior to the individual	The whole (city) is prior in nature to its parts
Natural slave	One lacking the deliberative faculty (Aristotle's uneasy doctrine)
Household (<i>oikos</i>)	Basic natural unit; root of "economics"
Constitution (<i>politeia</i>)	The arrangement of offices; defines the <i>polis</i>
Good vs corrupt constitutions	Monarchy/aristocracy/polity vs tyranny/oligarchy/democracy
Phronesis / sophia	Practical wisdom / theoretical wisdom
Rule of law	Law supreme in general; men decide particular cases

Exam pointers

- Frame Aristotle as **empirical/naturalist** vs Plato's **idealist** — the key contrast of the week.
- Reproduce the six-fold classification of constitutions (3 good / 3 corrupt) and the good-vs-corrupt test (common vs self-interest).
- Explain **man as political animal** + polis prior to the individual via the *telos* argument.
- Be able to state *and criticise* Aristotle's natural slavery argument (the convention/conquest objection).

Galbraith — 'A Look at the Landscape'

Book: John Kenneth Galbraith, *A History of Economics: The Past as the Present* (1987), **ch. I**, pp. 1–8.

Chapter résumé

Galbraith's opening chapter is a **manifesto for reading economics historically**. His central claim: **economic ideas are always a product of their own time and place**, so they can't be understood apart from the world they interpret — and as that world changes, ideas must **transform or lose relevance**. He explains what his history will and won't do (central ideas over exhaustive detail; heavy focus on the last century's money/banking/trade debates), attacks the vested interest that makes economics resist change, and names the discipline's **two central subjects**: the theory of value (prices) and the theory of distribution (wages, interest, profit, rent). He notes a historical shift of emphasis from **value/prices** toward **distribution** and the aggregate performance of the economy (employment, growth). Finally he defends writing a **critical** (not detached) history and warns against economic **forecasting**.

★ **The heart of the chapter: economic ideas are always a product of their own time and place** — to understand economics you must read its ideas against the world that produced them; when the world changes, the ideas must change too.

Key concepts / "modes" to use

- **History-of-ideas approach** — you cannot understand economics without its history.
- **Ideas as products of time & place** — the book's organising thesis.
- **Theory of value (prices) vs theory of distribution (wages/interest/profit/rent)** — the two great subjects.
- **Shift from scarcity/value to affluence/distribution/aggregate** — how the subject's centre of gravity moved.
- **Vested interest & resistance to change** — why comfortable ideas persist.
- **Limits of forecasting** — economists can't reliably predict.

Section-by-section main points

Why the history matters

- "There can be no understanding of economics without an awareness of its history." Economic ideas' authors owe a huge debt to predecessors; the "controlling ideas" are often lost in the mass of writing.
- **Core thesis:** *economic ideas are always and intimately a product of their own time and place; they cannot be seen apart from the world they interpret.* As the world changes, ideas are **transformed** — or become irrelevant.

What this history will do

- Not merely a history of ideas: he ties ideas to the **events that shaped them**, and emphasises **central ideas** over exhaustive detail — with special attention to the **last century** (intense debate over **banking, money, monetary policy, international trade, tariffs**).
- Change in economics is **resisted** — those who benefit from the *status quo* resist change; established ideas persist because they serve a **vested interest**.
- Two great organising reference points: **Adam Smith** and the modern era (Ricardo, the Industrial Revolution, **Keynes**, the Great Depression). (*In the book, Part I = "before Adam," Ch. II = "After Adam."*)

The two central subjects of economics

- **Theory of value** — what determines **prices** (and the value of goods).
- **Theory of distribution** — how the proceeds are shared: **wages, interest, profit, rent** (returns to labour, capital, land).
- Historically, **prices/value** were the very centre of the subject (esp. 18th c.). In modern, more affluent times, **distribution of income** and the **aggregate performance** of the economy — employment, growth, fluctuations, depressions — have become the more urgent, "most sensitive" questions.

- Beyond value & distribution lie the questions of **institutions** (banks, firms, government) and the larger **political and social framework** (capitalism, the welfare state, socialism/communism) — and when these change, economics undergoes "rather major change."

On method and forecasting

- The history should be told in **clear, agreeable English**, and can legitimately be written for **enjoyment** as well as instruction.
- Galbraith writes a **critical** history (he'll exercise judgment, not feign detachment) — economics is a "theater of avowed and strongly expressed argument."
- **Beware forecasting**: economists cannot reliably predict; the future is unknowable. (Keynes: "*In the long run we are all dead.*") A forecaster who truly *knew* the future would use the knowledge himself, not sell it.
- **Marshall's definition** (quoted): "Political Economy or Economics... is a study of mankind in the ordinary business of life."

Key terms

Term	Meaning
History of economic ideas	Studying economics through the development of its ideas
Ideas as product of time & place	Galbraith's central thesis
Theory of value	What determines prices / the value of goods
Theory of distribution	How income is shared: wages, interest, profit, rent
Aggregate performance	Economy-wide employment, growth, fluctuations
Vested interest	Why comfortable/status-quo ideas resist change
Critical history	History written with judgment, not feigned detachment

Exam pointers

- Nail Galbraith's **thesis** in one line: *economic ideas are products of their time and place; when the world changes, ideas must change too.*
- Know the **value vs distribution** distinction — and the historical **shift** toward distribution and aggregate performance.
- Use the **forecasting** warning (Keynes) and the **vested-interest** point as ready critiques.

Bridge across the week

Plato and Aristotle set the **normative-ideal** vs **empirical-natural** poles of political thought; Galbraith adds the meta-lesson that **all** such ideas — political and economic alike — must be read against the world that produced them. Aristotle's own "economics" (household management, Book 1 of the *Politics*) is a nice link to Galbraith's story of where economic thought *begins*.

★ Reading questions — worked answers

Study answers to Module 1's reading questions (Reeve on **Plato** · McClelland on **Aristotle** · Galbraith).
Each: a one-line **Answer**, then the depth for Plato and Aristotle.

1 · What is the best city/state — for Plato and Aristotle? Why?

Answer: Plato — the kallipolis, *one* ideal city ordered by knowledge of the Good. **Aristotle** — *it depends*: an ideal polis of the "good life," but the best **achievable** is the politeia (a mixed, middle-class constitution).

- **Plato (Reeve)**: the best city is the kallipolis — the purified "City-3" ruled by **philosopher-kings** who know the Form of the Good. It is best because it is ordered by **knowledge, not opinion**: the rational element rules, each class does the one job its nature fits (justice = specialization), and the city mirrors the well-ordered soul. It's a *single* ideal, reachable only by reason.
- **Aristotle (McClelland)**: refuses one blueprint. He separates the **ideal** state (*Politics* Books 7–8 — the "good life," right size/territory, citizens with leisure for virtue) from the **best practicable** — the politeia ("polity"), a "**mixed**" / **middle-class constitution**, because it is the most **stable** (the middle moderates between rich and poor). A regime is *good* when it rules in the **common interest**, and the **many collectively** may be wiser than the few.
- **Why they differ**: Plato the **idealist** derives the best city from the **Forms**; Aristotle the **empiricist** makes "best" plural and fitted to circumstances, and **criticises Plato's *Republic*** (Book 2) for abolishing family/property — which he says destroys natural affection and the household.

2 · Who should rule? Why?

Answer: Plato — the **philosopher-kings** (those who *know* the Good). **Aristotle** — whoever rules **in the common interest**, ideally the **virtuous**, but checked by the rule of law and often the **middle/many**.

- **Plato**: rule goes to those **best fitted by knowledge** — the **philosopher-kings**. Only knowledge of the Good (not opinion) can order the city rightly, just as **reason** should rule the soul. They rule **reluctantly** (they'd rather contemplate but must "return to the Cave") and **in the interest of all**.
- **Aristotle**: on "should **man or law** be supreme?" → **law supreme in general**, men deciding the particular cases law can't foresee. The **good** constitutions (monarchy, aristocracy, politeia) rule for the **common interest**; their corrupt twins (tyranny, oligarchy, democracy) rule for the rulers. A truly **kingly man** of outstanding virtue may rule — but only if for all; otherwise the **collective wisdom of the many** and the middle class are safer.
- **Contrast**: Plato = rule by the **one/few who know**; Aristotle = rule by the **virtuous serving the common good, constrained by law**.

3 · How are freedom and privacy protected in the kallipolis?

Answer: In the modern liberal sense they mostly **aren't** — privacy is *abolished* for the guardians and individual license is heavily restricted. Plato's defence: **true freedom = living by your *real interests***

under the rule of knowledge, and private property/family are competing interests that corrupt the rulers.

- **Privacy is removed, deliberately:** guardians have no private property and no private family (a "communism" of the rulers), plus a rigged marriage lottery, controlled education, and censorship of the arts — all to delete competing private interests so nothing rivals the good of the city.
- **Individual freedom is restricted, not protected:** the noble lie, fixed class roles and censorship constrain what citizens may do, believe and hear.
- **Plato's reply (Reeve, "Freedom and autonomy"):** distinguish **real interests** (what truly fulfils your nature → real happiness) from mere **desires**. Liberal *negative* freedom (do whatever you want) may not serve your real interests; **deliberative freedom** needs knowledge and the right education. So the kallipolis claims to deliver *more* **real** freedom — each person fulfilling their nature — precisely by restricting **license**. Privacy is sacrificed for the **unity** of the city.
- **The lecture's phrasing (BAP):** "*Freedom is preserved, since everybody is made equal and secure by the state and enabled to realize his/her potentials*" — i.e. freedom as **fulfilment**, not license (the same move as Reeve's real-interests defence).
- **Exam framing:** don't answer "freedom is protected." Say: *the kallipolis subordinates privacy and license to the city's unity and the citizens' real good; Plato redefines freedom as fulfilment under the rule of knowledge* — the anti-liberal move.

4 • What is honour? What is virtue?

Answer (the lecture's civic definitions — BAP): **Honour** = the ability & willingness to **defend the city/country against its enemies**. **Virtue** = a sense of **obligation & responsibility toward society**, to keep it from falling apart. Together: **Honour + Virtue** = **protection against anarchy or conquest by others** — and the way to stay in power.

- **Deeper — Plato (the soul):** in the tripartite soul, the **spirited** part seeks **honour, victory, reputation** (its people = the **honour-lovers/guardians**; a city ruled by them = a *timocracy*). Plato's four cardinal virtues map onto the parts — **wisdom** (rulers), **courage** (guardians), **temperance** (agreement on who rules), and **justice** = **each part doing its own work**; virtue is grounded in **knowledge** of the Good.
- **Deeper — Aristotle (the good life):** the polis exists so citizens can live "the good life" (*eudaimonia*) — a life of **virtue** built by **habit** and guided by **phronesis**. Honour is sought as a *sign* of virtue, but virtue is the higher, **intrinsic** end.

5 • What is idealism? What is materialism?

Answer: **Idealism** = reality is grounded in **ideas / forms / mind** (the intelligible is more real than the physical). **Materialism** = reality is grounded in **matter** (the physical/economic base is primary; ideas are derived). Plato is the classic **idealist**; the week's other pole leans **materialist/empirical**.

- **Idealism (Plato):** the truly real is the **Forms** — eternal intelligible patterns; the Form of the Good is the highest reality, and the physical world is a mere **shadow/copy** (the Cave). Knowledge is of Forms, not the changing senses — so rule belongs to those who *know* the Forms.

- **Materialism:** the **material/economic** world is primary; ideas and institutions are shaped by material conditions. The key political-economy example is **Marx's historical materialism** (the economic *base* determines the *superstructure* of ideas).
- **Aristotle sits between:** a **naturalist/empiricist** who studies the *actual* world (the polis as a natural organism, teleology in nature) — a counterweight to Platonic idealism, though not a strict materialist.
- **Galbraith tie-in:** his thesis that **economic ideas are products of their own time and place** is a *materialist* reading of ideas — fitting the week's **idealist (Plato) vs materialist/empirical (Aristotle, Marx, Galbraith)** contrast.
- **The lecture crystallises it (BAP): Ideas (Plato) vs Matter (Aristotle)** — as in **Raphael's *School of Athens*** (Plato points *up* to the eternal Forms; Aristotle gestures *down/out* toward the observed world).

★ Fun facts & memorable details

The sticky examples, witty asides and quotable lines from this week — great for essays, exam colour, or just remembering who's who.

Aristotle trivia (McClelland is full of it)

- McClelland says Aristotle was "**a snappy dresser**" who "**affected an aristocratic lisp.**"
- The **Lyceum's** covered walk was the *peripatos* — which is exactly why Aristotle's followers are called the **Peripatetics** (the "walking-about" philosophers).
- Aristotle's kinsman **Callisthenes** went east with Alexander to write the campaign history and recite Homer whenever Alexander got drunk and thought he was **Achilles** — possibly planted as **Aristotle's spy**. He was later executed.
- **The banquet at Opis (324 BC):** Alexander reconciled Macedonians and Persians, married **10,000** of his veterans to Asian concubines, and pleaded for *omonoia* (concord between the races). McClelland calls it "*the supremely anti-Aristotelian moment*" — it dissolved the Greek/barbarian distinction Aristotle's reason had so carefully drawn.
- In Aristotle's scheme of kingship, McClelland dryly notes, "*there are no queens.*"
- The word "**economics**" comes from Greek *oikonomikos* — **household management** (*Politics* Book 1).
- The historian **Polybius** later coined "**ochlocracy**" (mob-rule) for Aristotle's corrupt form of "democracy."
- The *Politics* may literally be a **bundle of students' lecture notes** — which is why scholars agree "the book is a mess."

Plato trivia

- Plato came from top-drawer Athenian aristocracy (related to **Solon**); his brothers **Glaucon and Adeimantus** are characters in the *Republic*.
- The **noble lie / myth of the metals:** citizens are told they were born with **gold, silver, or bronze** in their souls, to justify the class system.
- The ideal city runs a **rigged marriage lottery** (eugenics) and gives its guardians **no private property and no family** — a "communism" of the rulers.

- Plato would **expose deformed infants** and refuse to treat the incurably ill: medicine should restore people to a *worthwhile* life, not merely prolong it.
- Plato's three great images for knowing the Good: the **Sun**, the **Divided Line**, and the **Cave**.

Galbraith / economics

- Galbraith's one-line thesis: "*economic ideas are always and intimately a product of their own time and place.*"
- **Marshall's** still-quoted definition: economics is "*a study of mankind in the ordinary business of life.*"
- The **forecaster's paradox**: anyone who truly knew the economic future would quietly use the knowledge to get rich — not sell it in a newsletter. (Hence Keynes: "*In the long run we are all dead.*")
- Galbraith subtitled his book "**A Critical History**" — he refuses to pose as a detached, dispassionate scientist.

Module 2: Renaissance and Early-Modern Political Theory — from Cosmopolis to *Stato* to the Social Contract

Readings: McClelland, *A History of Western Political Thought*, ch. 11 (Hobbes, pp. 191–228) · Grotius (Boisen, *Political Thinkers*-style chapter) **Focus:** Thomas Hobbes: *Leviathan and the social covenant* · Hugo Grotius *and the world system of states*.

Theme of the module: the long shift from the medieval **Cosmopolis** (one universal Christian moral-legal order — Module 1's Aquinas) to the modern world of **sovereign states**. Three moves: **Machiavelli** frees politics from morality and invents the autonomous *stato* → **Hobbes** gives that state a **contractual foundation** and a *science* of absolute **sovereignty** → **Grotius** builds the **world system of states** bound by **natural law** (the birth of international law).

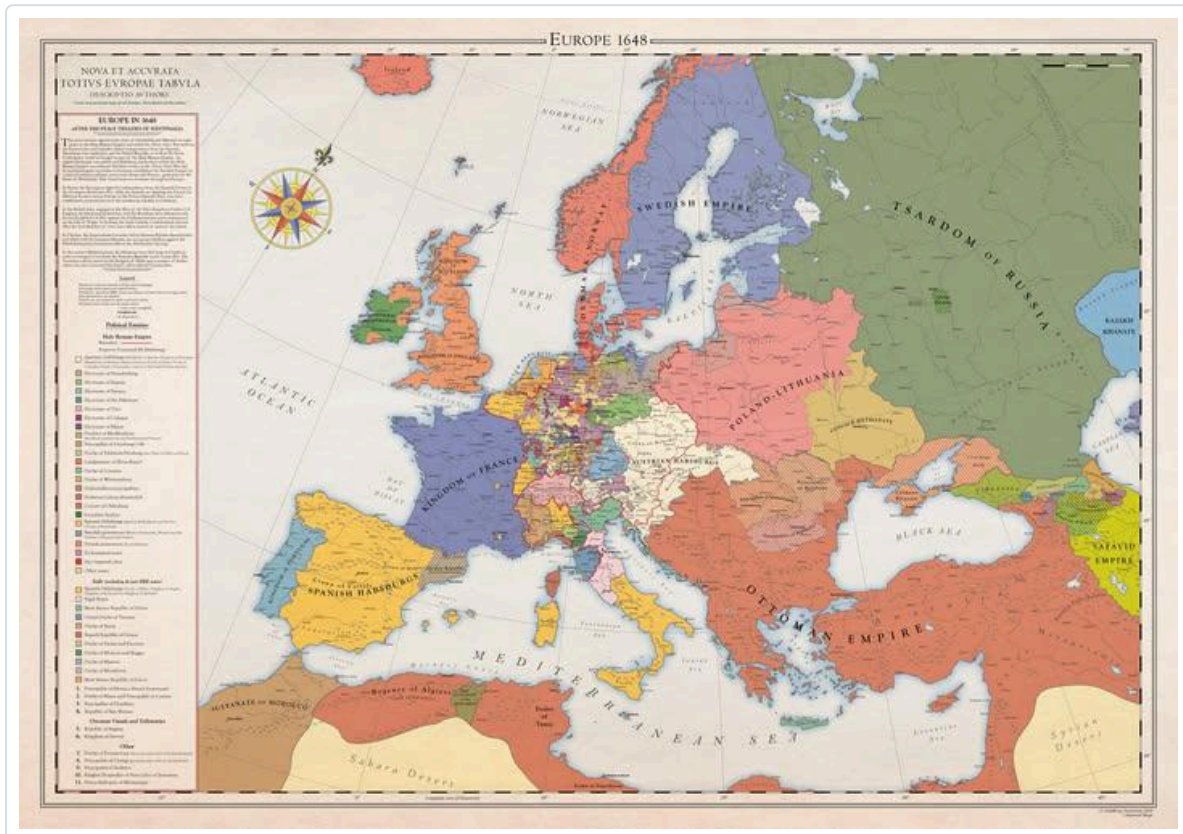
★ **The heart of the module — each thinker in one idea** (keep these in view):

- **Machiavelli → the *stato*:** politics is its own domain, freed from ethics; built on a fixed, pessimistic view of human nature.
- **Hobbes → the social covenant:** from a **state of nature** ("war of all against all") rational egoists **covenant with each other** to authorise an **absolute sovereign** (Leviathan) — anything less collapses back into war.
- **Grotius → the world system of states:** a **natural law** of universal rights & duties (binding "even if God did not exist") governs sovereigns too — grounding property, the free sea, and a **just-war** international order.

Lecture frame (Popp-Madsen — from the deck). (*The deck is the skeleton; the readings below add the flesh.*)

- **The big story — how political power kept being re-grounded:** Greek antiquity = politics is part of **ethical life** (the *zoon politikon*, the good life) → **Middle Ages** = the **Church** is the authority, religion supplies the rules, **God is the ultimate sovereign** → **17th-century early modernity** = the ground shifts to **power, conflict and self-interest**, and to **political institutions and the state**. Hobbes and Grotius are the thinkers of that last shift.

- **The Westphalian system** (the world Hobbes & Grotius write into): after 1648 Europe becomes a set of **sovereign states**, each with ① **exclusive sovereignty over its own territory**, ② **non-interference** in others, and ③ **legal equality** of states — and crucially **no supranational authority** above them (a rejection of the Catholic Church and Holy Roman Empire). *In plain terms*: the map stops being one Christendom and becomes a patchwork of independent states that recognise **no boss** above them.
- **The hinge between the two thinkers**: Hobbes solves order *inside* the state (domestic anarchy → sovereign). **But what governs the space *between* sovereign states**, where there is no super-sovereign? That gap is exactly what **Grotius** tries to fill with international law.



How to read it (the Westphalian map). Each colour is a sovereign state after 1648. The takeaway isn't the individual borders but the **pattern**: Europe is now a **mosaic of many independent sovereigns** — the fragmented **Holy Roman Empire** (centre) is a jumble of statelets — with **no emperor or pope ruling over the whole**. This is the "international anarchy" Hobbes says has no cure and Grotius says can be tamed by a **law of nations**.

McClelland — Hobbes: *Leviathan* and the Social Covenant

Chapter résumé

McClelland reads Hobbes's *Leviathan* (1651) as "*the first masterpiece of social-contract theory*" — yet a deeply **untypical** one: contract language was invented to justify *resistance*, but Hobbes turns it into an argument **for absolute government**, "driving a coach and four through all the libertarian conclusions." Written amid the **English Civil War**, it builds the state **geometrically** from a bleak view of human nature: from

a state of nature ("war of every man against every man," life "solitary, poor, nasty, brutish, and short"), self-interested **rational egoists** reason their way to a **covenant** transferring their unlimited Right of Nature to a **Sovereign** who is *not himself a party* to the contract — and whose power must therefore be **absolute and undivided**, because anything less slides back into the state of nature.

★ **The heart:** Hobbes's chain — **state of nature** (war of all against all) → the **Right of Nature** is a curse everyone would shed → reason's **Law of Nature** says "seek peace" → so men **covenant with each other** to authorise one **Sovereign** (who stays outside the deal) → sovereignty must be **absolute & undivided**, or you're back in the war.

The red thread. Read the whole argument as a **geometry**: the *axiom* is man as a **rational egoist**; the *theorems* are the Laws of Nature, the Social Contract, and absolute Sovereignty. For any step ask: *how does self-interested fear drive it, and why does it force the conclusion that the sovereign must have everything?*

Key concepts / "modes" to use

- State of nature — no government → "war of all against all."
- Right of Nature (a *permission*: unlimited liberty to preserve yourself) vs Law of Nature (a *command* of reason: **seek peace**).
- The social covenant — every man with every man; the sovereign is **beneficiary, not party**.
- **Sovereign / Leviathan** — the "mortal god"; **authorisation** ("what my agent does, I do"); **absolute & undivided**.
- Iniquity vs injury · sovereignty by institution vs acquisition · the efficiency constraint.

Section-by-section main points

| The Machiavelli bridge — the autonomous *stato*

Core: Machiavelli supplies the ground Hobbes builds on — **politics as its own domain**, cut loose from morality and religion, resting on a fixed, pessimistic view of human nature.

- *The Prince*: no natural law, no scripture — Machiavelli simply "treats those assumptions as if they were not there." He wants **axioms that always work**, so he assumes men are "always very bad" ("heads he wins, tails he doesn't lose").
- **Fear over love** — "*treat everybody as a potential assassin*"; better to be feared than loved (Caligula's *Oderint dum metuant* — "let them hate, provided they fear"). **Virtù vs Fortuna**: skill meeting luck. (McClelland: "*Machiavelli anticipates Hobbes*.")

| Hobbes's method — a geometry of man

Core: Hobbes builds politics like **Euclid** — from axioms about human nature to theorems — using the **new science** (matter in **motion**).

- **Materialist psychology**: humans are objects in **motion** (appetite/aversion); happiness is continual motion, not Aristotle's "rest." **Rational egoists** — Macpherson's "possessive individualists," "market-men" (the striking claim: "*a rising bourgeoisie requires an absolutist state*").

| The state of nature — the war of all against all

Core: strip away government and you get **rough natural equality** → mutual fear → a **war of all against all** — a *disposition* to fight, not constant battle.

- *In plain terms:* imagine no police, no courts, no laws. Since **anyone can kill anyone** (even the weakest can kill the strongest by stealth or in their sleep), nobody can ever feel safe. Everyone reasons that their **only security is to strike first / dominate others** — but everyone is thinking the same, so you get permanent mutual suspicion. It's "war" not because people fight all the time, but because the **threat never lifts** (like bad weather: not constant rain, but a settled *inclination* to storm).
- **Equality:** "no man is so strong that he cannot be killed by another by stealth" → everyone is a threat. Three drivers: **competition** (gain), **diffidence** (fear/safety), **glory** (reputation). "*Part of man's nature is anti-social, while the other part can only be satisfied through social living.*"
- **War as a condition:** "*the nature of War consisteth not in actual fighting, but in the known disposition thereto.*" The famous verdict: life is "**solitary, poore, nasty, brutish, and short.**"

| Right of Nature vs Law of Nature

Core: the **Right** of Nature is a *permission* (do anything to survive); the **Law** of Nature is a *command* of reason (**seek peace**) — and reason tells you to *give up* the unlimited right.

- **Right of Nature** = unlimited liberty of self-preservation — but since *everyone* has it, it's "a millstone" you'd be wise to shed.
- **Law of Nature** (a "precept found out by reason" forbidding self-destruction): 1st — "**seek peace, and follow it**"; 2nd — **lay down your right to all things, as far as others will too**. In the state of nature these bind *in foro interno* (in conscience) but not *in foro externo* (in act) — no one dares go first.

| ★ The social covenant — how you escape the state of nature

Core: you **can't make law by agreement** (who'd go first? who'd enforce it?) — so instead, **by agreement choose a law-giver:** everyone **covenants with everyone else** to transfer their Right of Nature to, and authorise, one **Sovereign**.

- **The key twist:** the covenant is **of every man with every man** — NOT with the sovereign. The sovereign is the **beneficiary, not a contracting party**, so *he makes no promise and can never "breach" the contract*. Everyone makes the leap into civil society **except the sovereign, who stays in the state of nature**.
- **Authorisation / representation:** the people **authorise everything the sovereign does** → "*what my agent does, I do... his will is my will.*" A people has a will **only through its representative** (the sovereign).
- **Institution vs Acquisition:** by **covenant** (the paradigm case) or by **conquest** (the ordinary historical case) — same result, because **fear doesn't invalidate a contract** ("all contracts are made through fear"; the man on a sinking ship "very willingly" throws his goods overboard).

| The Sovereign / Leviathan — absolute, undivided, a "mortal god"

Core: the commonwealth is **Leviathan**, an "artificial man" / "**mortal god**"; because the sovereign is authorised by all, his power must be **absolute and undivided**.



How to read it (the *Leviathan* frontispiece, 1651). This one picture is Hobbes's argument. The **giant sovereign** is literally made of the **multitude** — hundreds of individuals whose authorisation composes his body (the "artificial man"). He towers **over the land** (he holds the peace of the whole commonwealth), and he grips **both swords of power at once: a sword** (civil/temporal authority, left) **and a bishop's crosier** (religious/spiritual authority, right) — Hobbes's point that sovereignty must be **undivided**, ruling church *and* state. The Latin banner (Job 41) reads "*there is no power on earth to compare with him.*" The panels below mirror the two powers — civil (castle, crown, cannon) vs ecclesiastical (church, mitre, thunderbolts of excommunication).

- **Sovereignty is an office of the state, not the ruler's personal privilege (Popp-Madsen).** Hobbes describes the **rights of the office of sovereignty (i.e. the state)**, not the "advices" a particular ruler should follow. *In plain terms:* he's defining what **the position of Sovereign** may do — whoever fills it — not giving one king personal tips. This is why he says he founds **modern political thought**, and why the deck asks: "**Is Hobbes the first liberal?**" — his absolute state is built from **individuals' voluntary choices**, and the powers belong to the **institution**, not the person.
- **Iniquity vs injury** (crucial): the sovereign, being a man, *can* act wickedly (**iniquity**) — but he can never do a subject an **injury** (an *unlawful* act), because he makes the law and the subject authorised him → "the supposed injury is something I have done to myself."

- Powers include: law, courts, war & peace ("the sword of justice is also the sword of war"), **censorship** (he even fixes the meaning of "just" and "unjust"), control of religion, appointments, honours — and it **repudiates all prior covenants, including any "covenant with God."**
- **The only right you keep = self-preservation:** "no man is obliged to walk unbound to the scaffold." Otherwise a rational man sheds his Right of Nature entirely.

Why absolutism — anything less collapses into war

Core: you can't limit the sovereign by contract, and you can't set up a judge over him without an infinite regress ("why stop at three?") that ends in "**the state of nature by another name.**"

- Stark disjunction: "*Either you choose to live under a Sovereign or you don't*" — divided/limited sovereignty just breeds rival sovereigns → **civil war**.
- **The real (non-legal) limit — the efficiency constraint:** the sovereign's *powers* are unlimited but his *power* (capacity to enforce) is not. Order holds **only while subjects fear the sovereign more than they fear each other**; when that reverses, "the rebellion has already happened internally."
- **International anarchy:** "*covenants without the sword are but breath*" — with no super-sovereign over states, there's no peace between them (McClelland: why the League of Nations/UN are "bound to fail"). (*This is exactly the gap Grotius tries to fill.*)
- (*Aside — the **political-obligation controversy**: does Hobbes give only **prudential** reasons to obey, or a real **moral** duty? If the Laws of Nature are genuinely **God's commands**, obligation is moral; if "mere dictates of prudence," you obey only when watched.*)

Cases & examples

- **English Civil War (1642–51):** each attribute of sovereignty maps onto a live dispute — control of the **army/militia** (the 1642 trigger), **religion**, the **Common Law** "ancient constitution," the sale of honours. *Leviathan* was double-edged: usable by Charles I, Cromwell, and Charles II.
- **The Norman Conquest:** Hobbes implies William was "a true Sovereign by the free consent of the defeated English" at Hastings — demolishing the Whig "Norman Yoke" story (sovereignty by **acquisition**).
- **Grimmelshausen's *Simplicissimus* / the Thirty Years War** — the real-world picture of the state of nature (many sovereigns fighting for mastery).

Key terms

Term	Meaning
State of nature	Life without government → "war of all against all"
Right of Nature	<i>Permission</i> : unlimited liberty to preserve yourself
Law of Nature	<i>Command</i> of reason; 1st = seek peace
Social covenant	Every man with every man authorises a sovereign
Sovereign as beneficiary not party	Why the sovereign can't "breach" the contract
Leviathan / "mortal god"	The commonwealth as an artificial person
Authorisation	"What my agent does, I do" — a people wills only via its sovereign
Iniquity vs injury	Wickedness (possible) vs an <i>unlawful</i> act (impossible to a subject)
Institution vs acquisition	Sovereignty by covenant vs by conquest
Efficiency constraint	Order lasts only while subjects fear the sovereign most

Exam pointers

- Run Hobbes's chain cold: state of nature → right vs law of nature → **the covenant of every man with every man** → absolute sovereign.
- Nail *why* the sovereign is **beneficiary, not party**, and what follows (no breach, no right of resistance beyond self-preservation).
- Explain the iniquity vs injury distinction and the **regress argument** for why sovereignty can't be divided.
- Use "*covenants without the sword are but breath*" to link Hobbes to the **international** problem Grotius addresses.

Grotius — Natural Law and the World System of States

Chapter résumé

Hugo Grotius (1583–1645), Dutch jurist, aimed to "*formulate a set of universal rights and duties that would secure peace by constraining states in their internal and external relations.*" Amid the confessional chaos of the Thirty Years War he **rehabilitated natural law** on a **minimal, universal** basis everyone could accept, and applied it to the relations *between* sovereigns — earning him the title "**father of modern international law.**" His key move: natural law's obligatory force holds "**even if God did not exist**" (*etsi Deus non daretur*); from human **natural rights** (self-preservation, and the derived rights of **property** and **punishment**) he builds an order of sovereign states bound by a **law of nations** and a theory of **just war**. Unlike Hobbes, Grotius holds humans are **naturally sociable**.

★ **The heart:** there is a **universal natural law** — knowable by reason, binding even "if God did not exist" — that gives individuals **natural rights** (self-preservation → property → punishment) and applies **equally to states**. That's the foundation of the **world system of states**: free seas, property from occupation, and a **just-war** order in which even war is subject to law.

The red thread. Grotius scales **one idea** — **universal natural law/rights** — **up from individuals to states**. For each topic ask: *what does natural law permit or require here, and how does that constrain sovereigns?* Keep contrasting with **Hobbes**: same self-preservation start, but Grotius's humans are **sociable**, his natural law is genuinely **obligatory**, and his sovereign *can* be bound.

Key concepts / "modes" to use

- **Natural law** — universal, immutable principles; known **a priori** (right reason) & **a posteriori** (agreement of nations); source = God, content = human nature.
- The "**impious hypothesis**" (*etsi Deus non daretur*) — natural law binds *even if God did not exist*.
- **Natural rights** (subjective — a *power* one "has"): self-defence & self-preservation → **property & punishment**.
- **Mare Liberum** — the free sea as a state of nature (grounds free navigation & trade).
- **Appetitus societatis** — humans are **naturally sociable** (vs Hobbes).
- The **world system of states** + **just war** (four just causes) + the right to punish.

Section-by-section main points

Natural law — secularised and universal

Core: natural law = **universal, unchanging moral principles**, the same for everyone everywhere, that we work out by **reason** — a *minimal* moral basis everyone could accept *despite* Europe's ferocious religious splits.

- *In plain terms:* Grotius wanted a set of moral rules so basic that **Catholics, Protestants and non-Christians could all agree on them**, so they could settle disputes without first agreeing about God. That's the whole point of grounding law in **reason + human nature** rather than in one church's doctrine.
- **How we know its content** — **two routes: a priori** (by **right reason**, deduced from our rational and social nature) *and* **a posteriori** (by looking at the rules "to which all civilised nations subject" — because "*a universal effect requires a universal cause*").
- **Dual foundation** — **reason and God, each standing alone**: its **content** comes from human nature; its **obligatory force** rests on *both* right reason *and* God, "each independently able to carry the weight." Grotius explicitly loosens the medieval tie — natural law is **not** simply part of God's "eternal law" (contrast **Suárez**, who put the Ten Commandments inside natural law).
- *(Background debate he sidesteps — **voluntarism vs intellectualism**: is a thing good *because God wills it* (voluntarism) or does *God will it because it is good* (intellectualism)? Finnis reads Grotius as **mediating**: the **content** of natural law can be worked out on its own, but its **binding force** still comes from the divine will.)

★ The "impious hypothesis" — *etsi Deus non daretur*

Core: the famous line — natural law "*would take place, though we should even grant... that there is no God.*" Its obligatory force seems **independent of God's existence**.

- *In plain terms:* Grotius runs a **thought-experiment** — "*pretend*, just for argument, that there's no God: the basic moral rules would **still** hold." The point isn't to deny God; it's to show the rules are **so solid that people who disagree about religion can still all accept them**. That's how you get a law everyone in a war-torn, multi-faith Europe can share.
- **The qualification (don't miss it):** the *very next sentence* names God as Creator "to be obeyed in all things" — so it's **not atheism** (his translator Barbeyrac was "so perturbed" he added a footnote insisting on God). **Haakonssen/Boisen:** it's a **deliberately vague device** to lift natural law *above* confessional quarrels, not a metaphysical denial. **Source of the law = God; contents = human nature.** (*This is the move that starts to secularise natural law — hugely influential.*)

Natural rights — the *suum*, and rights as a power

Core: rights are **derived from facts about human nature** (chiefly sociability); a **subjective right** is "*something the individual possesses*" — a **power (*potestas*) over oneself** (liberty) or a claim over others/things. Grotius is "the first to give a systematic account of **subjective** natural rights."

- *In plain terms — the big shift:* the old idea of "right" meant "**the right thing to do**" (an objective rule out there). Grotius flips it to a right as **something you have** — a personal power/possession you can point to and claim ("*this is mine, my liberty, my property*"). That "**rights as possessions**" idea is the seed of the whole modern language of individual rights. Grotius's own words: a right is "*a moral Quality annexed to the Person, enabling him to have, or do, something justly.*"
- Man is by nature **free and *sui iuris*** (= *his own master, subject to no one*); the starting point is the ***suum*** ("*one's own*" — your life, body, liberty, possessions). **Two primary rights:** self-defence & self-preservation → **two secondary claim-rights:** property and punishment (these are the **four rights that can justify war**).
- **Rights are limited by a duty** not to injure others: "*the very nature of injustice consists in nothing else but the violation of another's rights.*" (*He separates **justice = respecting others' rights** — what law can enforce — from **higher virtues** like generosity/mercy, which it can't; the state secures the first, not the second.*)

The Free Sea (*Mare Liberum*) — the sea as a state of nature

Core: the **sea can't be owned** — it's "by nature open to all"; the high seas function like a state of nature, grounding a natural right to **free navigation and trade**. (*Mare liberum* = "free sea," against *mare clausum* = "closed sea.")

- *In plain terms:* the sea is different from land. **Land** you can physically **occupy** and fence off, so (by agreement) it can become private property. **The sea can't be occupied or fenced** — so it stays **everyone's**, and no state may shut others out of it. Hence **freedom of navigation and trade for all**.
- **Why it was written — the *Santa Catarina* / VOC:** a defence of the Dutch **breaking Portugal's monopoly** in the East Indies → a natural-law argument for **free international trade** (Grotius: undisturbed **commerce** is "part of the very fabric of humankind").
- **He demolishes Portugal's three claimed rights — possession, navigation, trade:**

- **Possession:** distinguishes **occupation from discovery** — "*first sighting is not a claim to title*." You can only claim what was **nobody's** (*res nullius*) before; but the East Indies **weren't** nobody's — **native rulers already possessed their lands** (echoing **Vitoria**: the Spanish "got no more authority over the Indians... than the Indians would have over the Spaniards" had they sailed to Spain). Nor could a **papal grant** (Alexander VI's 1493 bulls) give title — the pope has no temporal authority over non-Christians.
- **Navigation & trade:** "*God gave all things not to this man or that but to mankind*"; "**no man hath the power to grant a privilege against mankind**." So the sea stays common and trade can't be lawfully blocked.
- **vs Hobbes:** Grotius uses the state of nature **not to explain political authority** (as Hobbes does), but as a *device* to model the **norms of the high seas** — same concept, different job.

Property — occupation vs *dominium*

Core: we have a God-given **common use-right** (occupation) by nature; **private property** (*dominium*) is a **human convention** requiring agreement and law.

- "*God gave all things not to this man or that man, but to mankind*." Property is "an invention of societies." The question isn't *how to justify* private property (Locke's later question) but *the conditions under which it's permissible* — with a **right of necessity** (in extreme hardship you may access another's property) that puts **natural rights above civil rights**.

Sociability — *appetitus societatis* (the anti-Hobbes)

Core: humans have a natural **desire for society** (*appetitus societatis*) — an inclination to live peaceably with their own kind. This is Grotius's fundamental break from Hobbes.

- *In plain terms:* where **Hobbes** starts from people who are basically **dangerous to each other** (→ you need an all-powerful sovereign to keep the peace), **Grotius** starts from people who **naturally want to live together** peaceably (the Stoic *oikeiōsis*). So Grotius flatly rejects the line that "every creature only seeks its own private advantage." Same starting concern (self-preservation), **opposite view of human nature** → a much less absolutist politics.
- **Sociability is "thin," on purpose.** Because man is sociable, **keeping social order is fundamental to law** — but critics (Haakonssen, Harvey) call it a "**meagre**," **leave-others-alone** sociability: essentially *leave others to the enjoyment of their suum as long as they leave you to yours*. That thinness is deliberate — a **minimalist** account that avoids taking sides on *what the good life is* (again, to sidestep religious quarrels). We're also pushed together by **need** ("our lack of things").
- **Politics is built by voluntary agreement** — natural jurisdiction lies with the **individual**, "not a king or a pope." **Troubling corollary:** because you own your liberty, Grotius says you may **contract it away** — even into **slavery/servitude** (to escape death, debt or conquest). This let **Rousseau** brand him "**an apologist for absolutism**"; and Grotius allows only a **narrow right of resistance** — reserved for when the sovereign **breaks the founding contract**.

★ The world system of states — just war & the right to punish

Core: universal natural law applies **equally to states**; a **law of nations** with authority to arbitrate wars makes an ordered **society of states** — and even war is **subject to law**.

- *In plain terms:* Grotius's big claim against Hobbes — the space *between* states **need not be lawless**. Law rests on **human rationality**, not on a sovereign's will, so **the same natural law that binds individuals binds states too**, even though there's no world government to enforce it. That's the birth of **international law**.
- ***The Rights of War and Peace* (1625):** subject international relations, incl. war, to the **rule of law**. War is "*an instrument of right... undertaken for the sake of peace*": **just = the execution of a right; unjust = the execution of an injury**. "*Where the methods of justice cease, war begins.*"
- **Four just causes of war (*jus ad bellum*):** ① **self-defence** · ② **self-preservation** · ③ **recovery of property / a debt** · ④ **punishment**. (*A state has a right but only an "imperfect duty" to punish — it may act, but isn't obliged to.*)
- **Restraint in war (*jus in bello*):** a middle ground (*temperamenta*) between Erasmus's pacifism (which "bends the crooked stick too far the other way") and **unlimited war** — "just wars are those wherein rules are observed."
- **The right to punish** (central to international order): derived from natural law (not mere revenge). Against Vitoria (who said conquistadors *couldn't* punish the American Indians for want of jurisdiction), Grotius argues "*war may be waged against those who sin against nature,*" since nature "*has jurisdiction over the whole of mankind.*" But he **warns against using punitive war as a pretext** ("civilising barbarous peoples"), and punishment must be **forward-looking/deterrent**, not vengeful (Plato: "no wise man punishes because an offence was committed, but that it may not be committed again").

★ **Worked example — Grotius's just war today: UN Article 51 & Putin's Ukraine war (from the deck).** Grotius's categories are *still the language of modern international law*. **UN Charter Article 51** guarantees "the inherent right of individual or collective **self-defence** if an armed attack occurs" — Grotius's just-cause ① in treaty form. Lawyers add two Grotian-style limits for **anticipatory self-defence**: **necessity** (the threat is imminent, no peaceful option) and **proportionality** (response fits the threat). **Putin (24 Feb 2022)** framed the invasion of Ukraine *precisely in this vocabulary*: he claimed "we have been left with **no other way to defend Russia**," invoked "**Article 51 of the UN Charter**," said the Donbas "People's Republics" had **appealed for help** (collective self-defence), and cast the war as **punishment** ("prosecution of those who committed crimes," "de-Nazification"). → *This is exactly the danger Grotius flagged: the just causes (**self-defence** and **punishment**) are the ones most easily turned into a **pretext**. Grotius gives you both the framework and the warning.*

Legacy

Core: "**father of international law**" (a title cemented by the 20th-c. jurist **Lauterpacht**; the term "international law" itself was coined by **Bentham**), and a pillar of the **social-contract tradition**.

- Influenced **Hobbes** (Tuck: Hobbes's philosophy is "a Grotian theory"), **Locke** (the natural right to **punish**), **Pufendorf**. *Contested legacy:* his **occupation/dominium** and **punishment** doctrines were later "invoked to rationalise European **empire**" — "empire is an inescapable feature of early-modern political thought."

Key terms

Term	Meaning
Natural law	Universal immutable principles; source = God, content = human nature
Impious hypothesis (<i>etsi Deus non daretur</i>)	Natural law binds "even if God did not exist"
Natural (subjective) right	A <i>power/potestas</i> one "possesses" over oneself or a claim on others
<i>Suum / sui iuris</i>	What is one's own / subject to no one (natural liberty)
<i>Mare Liberum</i>	The free sea — common to all, a "state of nature"
Occupation vs <i>dominium</i>	Common use-right (natural) vs private property (conventional)
<i>Appetitus societatis</i>	The natural human desire for society (vs Hobbes)
Just war (<i>jus ad bellum</i>)	4 just causes: self-defence, self-preservation, recovery/debt, punishment
Right to punish	Derived from natural law; enforces order among individuals & states
Law of nations / society of states	Universal natural law applied to sovereign states

Exam pointers

- Explain the impious hypothesis precisely (natural law "even if God did not exist") — and the qualification (not atheism; a universality device).
- Trace the **rights chain**: *suum* → self-preservation → **property** (occupation vs *dominium*) → **punishment**.
- Use *Mare Liberum* as the worked example (sea as state of nature → free trade).
- State the four just causes of war + the right to punish + Grotius's **restraint** (vs Vitoria; vs Erasmus).

★ Hobbes vs Grotius — the module's payoff

Core: both are pillars of **social-contract** theory and both start from **self-preservation** — but they split on **human nature**, and that split drives everything.

	Hobbes	Grotius
Human nature	Naturally in conflict → "war of all against all"	Naturally sociable (<i>appetitus societatis</i>)
Natural law	Reduced to self-security — the way <i>out</i> of the <u>state of nature</u>	Genuinely obligatory ; universal (binds "even if God did not exist")
State of nature — used for	To explain the origin of political authority	Not authority <i>per se</i> — a device (e.g. the free seas / justifying a war)
The sovereign & the contract	Sovereign is not a party → no breach, (almost) no right of resistance	Sovereign can be a party → a narrow right of resistance in extreme tyranny
Main worry	Domestic order (avoiding civil war)	International order (a law-governed society of states)
Legacy	Absolutism; the "science of the state"	International law; natural rights; (contested) empire

Where they meet: Grotius's line that there's no order without enforcement echoes Hobbes's "*covenants without the sword are but breath*" — but Grotius thinks natural law + sociability can bind sovereigns **without** a world-Leviathan, which is exactly what Hobbes denies.

★ Fun facts & memorable details

Sticky bits from Module 2 (Hobbes & Grotius).

Hobbes

- Life in the state of nature is "**solitary, poore, nasty, brutish, and short.**"
- The commonwealth is a "**mortal god.**"
- "**Covenants without the sword are but breath**" — Hobbes's one-line theory of international anarchy.
- "**Hobbes and Fear were born twins**" — born prematurely in **1588**, his mother's labour supposedly brought on by news of the **Spanish Armada**. Yet he was reportedly cheerful and **died at 91**; Charles II gave him a pension and enjoyed watching wits bait "**the Bear.**"
- He **discovered Euclid by accident** in a gentleman's library — and built *Leviathan* like a geometry.

Grotius

- The **impious hypothesis**: natural law would hold "*though we should even grant... that there is no God.*"
- **Child prodigy**: at the University of **Leiden** aged **11**; a law degree at ~16; Henry IV called him "*the miracle of Holland.*"
- **The book-chest escape**: sentenced to life in prison, he **escaped in 1621 hidden in a chest of books.**

- The **VOC** hired him to justify seizing the Portuguese carrack *Santa Catarina* — a prize worth ~**3 million guilders** ($\approx$ the entire annual revenue of the English government that year).
- "**International law**" as a term was coined by **Bentham**; Grotius's "father of international law" title was cemented by the 20th-c. jurist **Lauterpacht**.
- He **died in 1645 after surviving a shipwreck** on the way home from serving Queen Christina of Sweden.